



THE WISH MAKER
by ALI SETHI
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| By Rajni George |

Zaki, the wishmaker and the novel's fatherless narrator, has grown up in a household of strong women, whose most potent influences are his mother Zakia, groundbreaking journalist and absentee mother, Daadi, his fearless grandmother and his cousin Samar, who has escaped from her feudal background to live in Lahore with her mother's family. Zaki develops an almost preternatural closeness to Samar Api, whose first transgression becomes part of Zaki's own rites of passage as he is inducted into his country's political reality. Of course it becomes apparent that this early education is unavoidable growing up amidst Pakistan's turmoil as it repeats the same, endless cycles. In one memorable conversation, Daadi and her old friend acknowledge that nothing has changed; the army is back again, and the elections have led back to the same place, the same conversations and calls for change. The debates are familiar even today, of course, after Benazir Bhutto's death and the

The Personal is POLITICAL

A young boy and his cousin grow up together, yet irrefutably apart, in Ali Sethi's understatedly lyrical debut. Pakistan's latest talent has arrived, and gracefully.

current situation of crisis in Pakistan. Sethi feels that change is in the offing however; when asked if Pakistan will ever move from its feudalism, he is inclined to say it will, "if only because the landholdings are smaller in every inheritance". As he says: "Pakistanis are a generally resilient people. Decades of repression have taught them the tricks of survival."

The son of prominent Pakistani journalists Najam Sethi and Jugnu Mohsin, Sethi has learnt this growing up; in fact, he recreates some of what his own father experienced firsthand (*see extract*). Pakistan's progressives, he comments, "are more relevant today than they have ever

been: they are journalists, lawyers, artists, and are shaping the debate about Pakistan's ideology. The challenge for progressives is how to use the media, the judiciary and the streets to break conclusively the military-mullah bond that has led to this destruction (the chaos created by the military's encouragement of jihadist ideologies)."

Sethi's is a measured, often witty voice that shows admirable control over the history his protagonist has inherited, with a slick grasp of narrative that takes us from Daadi's history to Naseem, the maidservant's, easily. There are some wonderfully evoked scenes of the past; of Zakia's youth and the stories of its rebellions—



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